The Slow-Carb Diet

A practical guide: rules, food lists, meal plans & shopping list

What is it? The Slow-Carb Diet, popularized by Tim Ferriss in *The 4-Hour Body*, is a low-glycemic eating plan built on protein, legumes and vegetables, while avoiding "white" carbohydrates, sugar and fruit. One day a week you eat whatever you like (the "cheat day").

Note: This guide is general information, not medical advice. Check with your doctor before starting any diet, especially if you have diabetes, kidney disease, are pregnant, or take medication.

The 5 Rules

Rule #1 – Avoid "white" carbohydrates

Bread, rice, cereal, potatoes, pasta, tortillas, fried food with breading.

Rule #2 – Eat the same few meals over and over

Pick 3–4 proteins, 2–3 legumes and 2–3 vegetables and rotate them.

Rule #3 – Don't drink calories

Water, unsweetened tea, coffee and diet drinks are fine. No milk, juice or soda. Up to 1–2 glasses of dry red or white wine are allowed.

Rule #4 – Don't eat fruit

Fructose slows fat loss. Tomatoes and avocados are exceptions.

Rule #5 – Take one day off per week

Pick one day (often Saturday) and eat anything you want.

Daily Habits

- Eat within 30–60 minutes of waking, with about 30 g of protein.
- Eat 4 meals a day roughly every 4 hours; no snacking in between.
- Build each meal from protein + legumes + vegetables.
- Drink plenty of water (2+ liters/day).
- Season freely with spices, salsa, olive oil, butter and herbs.

Food Lists

Proteins	Legumes	Vegetables	Fats & extras
Eggs & egg whites	Lentils	Spinach, kale	Olive oil, butter
Chicken breast / thigh	Black beans	Broccoli	Nuts (small amounts)
Beef, grass-fed	Pinto beans	Asparagus	Avocado, tomato
Fish (salmon, cod, tuna)	Red beans	Green beans	Salsa, mustard
Pork (lean)	Chickpeas (limited)	Cabbage, sauerkraut	Spices & herbs
Whey/pea protein isolate	Soybeans / edamame	Peas, Brussels sprouts	Hummus (small amounts)

Foods to Avoid

Category	Examples
White carbs	Bread, rice, pasta, cereal, potatoes, tortillas, oats
Sugar & sweets	Candy, desserts, sweetened drinks, honey, agave
Fruit	All fruit and fruit juice (except tomato, avocado)
Dairy	Milk, cheese, yogurt (small amount of cream in coffee, cottage cheese ok per some versions)
Fried foods	Anything with breading or batter

Sample Meal Combinations

Meal	Idea
Breakfast	3 eggs scrambled with spinach + black beans + salsa
Lunch	Grilled chicken, lentils, steamed broccoli, olive oil
Dinner	Baked salmon, asparagus, pinto beans
Snack (optional)	Boiled eggs, handful of almonds

7-Day Sample Meal Plan

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	Scrambled eggs, black beans, salsa	Chicken, lentils, green beans	Beef stir-fry with broccoli
Tue	Egg-white omelet with spinach, pinto beans	Tuna, chickpeas, mixed greens	Baked cod, asparagus, lentils
Wed	Eggs, avocado, red beans	Turkey chili (beans, tomato)	Pork loin, sauerkraut, spinach
Thu	Protein shake (no fruit), almonds	Chicken thigh, black beans, kale	Salmon, Brussels sprouts
Fri	3-egg frittata with veggies	Beef & bean salad	Shrimp, edamame, cabbage slaw
Sat	**CHEAT DAY** – eat anything	**CHEAT DAY**	**CHEAT DAY**
Sun	Eggs, lentils, tomato	Grilled chicken, pinto beans, salad	Steak, green beans, hummus

Cheat Day Tips

- Stay on plan until the cheat day; don't "save up" by skipping meals.
- Eat normally in the morning, then enjoy; avoid binging to discomfort.
- Return to the plan the next morning with a protein-rich breakfast.
- Some people drink ice water or do light exercise before the cheat day to blunt glucose spikes.

Weekly Shopping List

Proteins	Legumes & Veg	Pantry
■ Eggs (2 dozen) ■ Chicken breast/thighs ■ Lean beef ■ Salmon / cod ■ Canned tuna ■ Pork loin ■ Protein powder	■ Lentils ■ Black beans ■ Pinto beans ■ Chickpeas ■ Spinach / kale ■ Broccoli ■ Asparagus ■ Green beans	■ Olive oil ■ Butter ■ Almonds ■ Salsa ■ Spices ■ Avocados ■ Tomatoes

Tips for Success

• Batch-cook proteins and beans on Sunday; use canned beans to save time.

• Weigh yourself and take measurements weekly; expect fat loss to vary.

• Add resistance training 2–3 times a week to preserve muscle.

• If you feel dizzy or unwell, add salt/electrolytes and consult a doctor.

Weekly Tracker

Day	Meals on plan?	Water (L)	Notes
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat (cheat)			
Sun			